

MIDAS Heritage – The UK Historic Environment Data Standard (Version 1.1, October 2012)

Objectives	Principles	Domain	Architectural Layout
Provide a common format for data sharing to promote consistency, enhance retrieval, and facilitate exchange	MIDAS XML is a component of the FISH interoperability toolkit, supporting standardized information exchange	Environmental domain: The UK historic environment	Three-tier structure (Themes, Information Groups, Units of Information) is flexible and fairly simple, with usually a handful of required units of information per information group. Forms a web-like structure with certain mandatory and optional relationships between information groups, represented well by diagrams in the documentation
Help migrate data from old information systems to new ones	Explicitly does not define software or file formats to use, prescribe names for database fields, or specify indexing terms to use – Leaving these decisions up to each user community supports flexibility and cross-system compatibility	Communities served include: Conservation officers, archaeologists, heritage managers and advisors, preservation groups and societies, academic and government research groups, software vendors	Use of optional units of information and relationships can add granularity, especially with repeatable units and relationships
Promote the evolution of new technologies and		Object class domains: MIDAS Heritage main	Designed to be flexible and meet needs for a variety

systems, and ensure the survival of information as technology changes		themes are “Heritage Asset,” “Activity,” and “Information Sources,” covering respectively locations and physical objects, events and activities, and information objects	of communities— Main themes are divided based on major areas of interest and research, with supporting themes (Spatial Information, Temporal Information, Actor Information) to add supplemental detail across the main themes. Specification is for the framework and relationships rather than database fields or formats, allowing for flexibility and customization
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English Heritage. (2012, October 19). *Midas heritage - the UK historic environment data standard* | *historic england*. Historic England. <https://historicengland.org.uk/images-books/publications/midas-heritage/>

Using the View Metadata option on Metadata2go, I uploaded two files I had saved locally: a PDF of a knitting pattern and a .puz file of a crossword puzzle. Some thoughts:

- This tool is designed to extract and present as much metadata as possible for users, for a wide range of applications. The website specifically calls out the ability to view “hidden data,” with examples of ensuring your privacy before posting files online and of extracting useful information from photos.
- The metadata extraction is automated, though I assume there was some manual human involvement up-front in building it, specifying which elements to look for and how to display them, etc. There’s of course manual involvement in selecting and uploading a file, and I suspect a degree of human curation involved in the design as far as which file types to expect and accept—It processed my .puz, but that probably isn’t what this site is designed for.

- Unsurprisingly, the tool pulled way more information from my PDF than the puzzle. PDF is a much more common format with standardized and accessible metadata; .puz is a fairly niche file format designed for use with the application Across Lite, and according to what I found online (<https://code.google.com/archive/p/puz/wikis/FileFormat.wiki>), there's no official documentation of the format (though there's certainly enough info floating around that I was able to put my handmade puzzles into it to format them for the newspaper in undergrad). For the puzzle, the tool gave me the checksum, file name, file size, MIME type, two fields called "category" (value of "application") and "type" (value of "octet-stream"), which together comprise the MIME type, "application/octet-stream," and the raw header, which looks like it might be some Base64 stuff. Interestingly, it couldn't even provide the date I'd created/saved the file, let alone anything meaningful about the contents.
- By contrast, the data for the knitting pattern is abundant, including information about the original PDF's creation (made March 2019 in Adobe InDesign by the pattern designer) even though I didn't download it until December 2025. It includes details on each font used throughout the document, and each image embedded.
- This is way more info than I'm likely to ever need about a PDF, but thinking about the privacy implications is once again kind of scary. Does Xandy Peters know they put so much info about their creation of this document out into the open by publishing this pattern? Sure, I'm not going to do anything with knowing what version of InDesign they were using in 2019, but what else do we need to be thinking about every time we put something online?